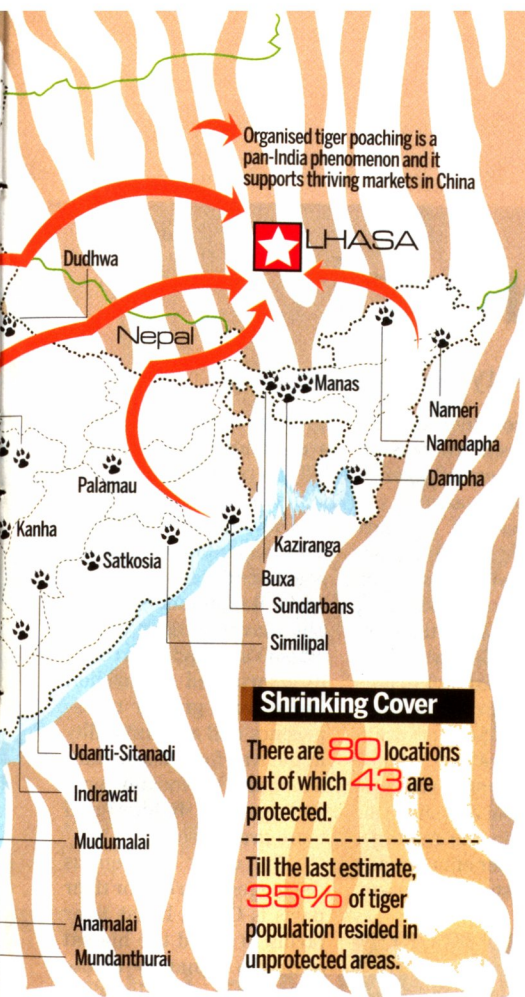


SANSAR CHAND (TOP) AND SHABEER HASSAN QURESHI, INDIA'S TOP TRADERS IN TIGER PARTS, ARE BEHIND BARS NOW

from the trap. Male tigers can weigh up to 225 kg, a tigress up to 136 kg. Then, using a razor-sharp knife, they skin the tiger on the spot. Then they slice it open and remove organs, including the penis which fetch high prices in China. Pardhis do the primary tanning of the skin at the site by stretch-drying the skin after applying turmeric and salt. They bury the carcass nearby, and come a week later to retrieve the bones when the rotten flesh has fallen away. The hunters can kill five tigers in one trip in the same forest. They will camp for a couple of months, eat deer and wild boar, and in the process kill not just tigers, but leopards as well.

To meet one such group of the Pardhis, we went to Bediya village in Khandwa district where they have shifted base from their hideouts in Katni to claim false compensation. Bediya has neatly built houses. A short distance away is where the Pardhis live in shanties that look as if recently built. They mob the car and enquire: if you are from the revenue department with compensation documents. The only sign of well-being are motorcycles, some without registration numbers. The motorcycles are used for meetings between traders and the hunters to get contracts to kill tigers for the international market for animal parts, a market next only to the illicit trade in drugs in magnitude. The wholesalers and traders of tiger's parts come on motorbikes to place orders, oversee the progress and arrange for delivery to Fatehpur, Kanpur, Ghaziabad and Delhi. While one half of the Pardhi population is involved in an audacious land scam, the other half is combing the jun-

out the bait—wild animal meat—to attract tigers and conceal iron traps along the path the tiger will take to the bait. It needs a dozen-men team to monitor the movement of the tigers and the patrolling routine of forest guards. Usually, the last patrol is around midnight and they are free to stalk the tiger undisturbed till late next morning. The success rate of tribal poachers is very high but the consequences for India's

national animal are tragic and inhuman. The jaws of the iron trap close with a great force; cracking the powerful leg of the tiger in two and holding it like a vice. The hunters arrive on the scene from their hiding place and thrust a thick bamboo pole with a pointed spear into the tiger's mouth and stuff some earth into it to make sure death is quick and quiet. It takes half a dozen men to release a dead tiger

Eyeballs

\$250-300 for a pair

Used to treat epilepsy and malaria.

Gall Bladder

\$400

The bile is used to treat convulsions and meningitis in children.

Teeth ▶

\$10/tooth

Used to treat fever, rabies and asthma.

Fat

\$400/kg

Used as a cure for vomiting, dog bites, bleeding, and haemorrhoids.



Claws ▲

\$480

Used as a sedative for insomnia.

Penis

\$200-500

Used in love potions and as an aphrodisiac.

Tail

\$600

In powdered form, said to treat skin diseases.